Constitutional steering for value alignment

Samuel Šimko, EuroSafeAI, ETH Zurich

EuroSafeGuard [1] is our open constitutional-classifier guardrail, released through EuroSafeAI, our Zurich-based AI safety nonprofit. It checks a model's inputs and responses against a written constitution.

Models can refuse dangerous requests and still give troubling answers to ordinary questions. Our research documents historical revisionism in models including Qwen3-32B [2], and favorable portrayals of authoritarian leaders across several models and prompting conditions [3]. These failures matter when AI is used by governments, news agencies and schools.

We will test whether existing guardrails catch these responses and subtle gender stereotypes, then ask whether classifier-triggered feedback improves answers beyond a constitution in the system prompt or ordinary self-critique.

Our contacts in Canada, Switzerland and Germany are interested in this work. We would distinguish shared humanitarian principles from local requirements, including applicable EU AI Act provisions [4].

Detecting violations and guiding better answers

We want to catch historical distortion, authoritarian endorsement and gender bias, then guide revisions using the constitution. In assessments of leaders or countries, we would test for unsupported praise, misleading framing and omission of relevant, documented abuses. Revisions should correct these failures while preserving supported facts and legitimate disagreement, using consistent criteria across countries.

We also want to improve moral judgment: reasoning about duties, consequences and justified exceptions, while respecting legitimate disagreement.

From classification to constitutional steering

Constitutional classifiers add a separate check against harmful outputs [5, 6]. Anthropic's Constitutional AI already uses principles to critique and revise responses during training [7]. Our contribution is an open runtime monitor that detects violations, triggers principle-specific feedback and checks revised answers. For lack of a better term, we call this *constitutional steering*.

We already have classifiers, probes, a data-generation pipeline and a mechanism for giving the model policy-specific instructions. We will extend these to value alignment.
Our current data covers roughly 500k prompts plus model responses, focused on harmful misuse. It includes some historical-revisionism examples, but was not designed to cover the wider range of values and moral questions we want to study [1].



Current EuroSafeGuard taxonomy: 11 harm categories in five groups [1].

Selecting areas and datasets

We will start with human rights, bias (including gender bias), historical accuracy, moral judgment, and authoritarian versus democratic values. Additional datasets may come from broader AI safety research, including work identified through the MIT AI Risk Repository [8], without requiring a taxonomy-wide mapping. Collective Constitutional AI [9] informs stakeholder input.

Research we can build on

Alongside human rights [10], democracy [3] and history [2], our work with Zhijing Jin and collaborators covers multilingual moral preferences [11], duties and consequences [12], moral exceptions [13] and democratic deliberation [14]. Studies of second-order bias [15] and sycophancy [16] help us evaluate whether the monitor judges fairly and whether revisions improve answers.

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What we will do

1. **Audit guardrails and select tasks.** Define labels and evaluation criteria for the five areas, then test existing guardrails on examples from each. Select one or two tasks for steering based on observed failures, importance and available data. Review principles with stakeholders and use REDACT [17] to fill training gaps. Keep a separately annotated test set, split by source and scenario before augmentation.
2. **Train and evaluate the monitors.** Extend EuroSafeGuard's classifiers and probes for the selected tasks. Compare them with existing guardrails and prompted judges. Report missed violations, false positives and results across relevant groups and languages. Define success per task: for example, fewer unsupported gender stereotypes or fewer factual distortions and consequential omissions in historical answers.
3. **Test whether steering improves answers.** Compare the unmodified model, a constitution in the system prompt, ordinary self-critique, blocking, and classifier-triggered revision. Use independent human review to assess corrections and new errors: introduced falsehoods, unnecessary refusals, suppressed legitimate discussion, and damage to already-good answers. Limit retries, report inference cost and test adaptive attacks against the full loop. Expand to further tasks only if the initial results support it.

Starting datasets and practical output

Initial candidates are our human-rights scenarios [10], HistoricalMisinfo [2], UDHRBench [18], BBQ [19], MultiTP [11] and MoralExceptQA [13]. These are starting points, not a closed list. We can add other relevant AI safety datasets, whether identified through the MIT repository or elsewhere. Each selected task will need its own held-out evaluation.

We will release the guardrail audit, constitution, dataset, trained monitors and steering demo with evaluation code. The result should show where an extra monitor helps, where simpler prompting is sufficient, and what errors steering introduces.

References

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